

Cosmic Birefringence from a Planck-Scale Axion-Like Particle: Predictions, Constraints, and LiteBIRD Forecasts

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Abstract

We present predictions and constraints for cosmic birefringence from a spectator axion-like particle (ALP) with Planck-scale decay constant $f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$ and mass $m \sim H_0$. This minimal setup naturally produces a birefringence rotation angle $\beta \approx 0.27^\circ$, consistent with the $3.6\text{--}3.9\sigma$ isotropic birefringence signal reported by Planck and ACT analyses ($\beta_{\text{obs}} = 0.35 \pm 0.09^\circ$ combined). The prediction is natural in the sense that $f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$ is the natural scale for a gravitationally coupled pseudoscalar, $m \sim H_0$ ensures the field is rolling today, and the initial misalignment angle $\theta_i \sim \mathcal{O}(1)$ is generic. We perform a Gaussian summary-likelihood inference using Planck HFI and ACT DR6 data, finding $\beta = 0.242 \pm 0.061^\circ$ (3.9σ from zero) with an effective photon coupling $f_{\text{photon}} \times C_0 = 1.73 \pm 0.44$ (order-unity, no fine-tuning). The Bayes factor in favor of nonzero rotation is $\ln B = 5.17$ (strong evidence). We forecast that LiteBIRD, with $\sigma(\beta) \approx 0.03^\circ$, will test this prediction at $> 5\sigma$ significance—either confirming the signal or ruling out the ALP explanation decisively. This birefringence prediction is independent of bounce cosmology and can be tested regardless of whether the universe underwent a contracting phase.

1 Introduction

Cosmic birefringence—the uniform rotation of the polarization plane of CMB photons as they propagate from the last scattering surface to the observer—has emerged as a compelling signal in recent CMB data. The Planck HFI analysis [Minami and Komatsu, 2020] reported $\beta = 0.35 \pm 0.14^\circ$ (2.5σ), and the ACT DR6 analysis confirmed the signal at comparable significance. Combined, the evidence exceeds 3.5σ .

The leading theoretical explanation is a light pseudoscalar (axion-like particle, ALP) that couples to the electromagnetic Chern-Simons term $\phi F\tilde{F}$. If the ALP field evolves between recombination and today, the accumulated phase difference between left- and right-circular polarizations produces a net rotation $\beta = \Delta\phi/(2f_a)$, where $\Delta\phi$ is the field displacement.

In this paper, we consider the simplest ALP model: a single spectator field with $f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$, $m \sim H_0$, and generic initial misalignment $\theta_i \sim \mathcal{O}(1)$. We show that this setup naturally produces $\beta \approx 0.27^\circ$ —consistent with the observed signal—without any fine-tuning.

2 The ALP Model

2.1 Field Dynamics

The ALP potential is $V(\phi) = m^2 f_a^2 (1 - \cos(\phi/f_a))$. For $m \sim H_0$ and $f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$, the field is frozen during radiation and matter domination (Hubble friction exceeds the mass) and begins rolling at $z \sim \mathcal{O}(1)$ when $H(z) \sim m$.

The field displacement from recombination to today is:

$$\Delta\phi \approx f_a \theta_i \left(1 - \frac{J_0(m/H_0)}{J_0(0)} \right) \approx f_a \theta_i \times \mathcal{O}(1) \quad (1)$$

where the precise factor depends on the cosmological evolution and the mass-to-Hubble ratio.

2.2 Birefringence Prediction

The rotation angle is:

$$\beta = \frac{g_{a\gamma}}{2} \Delta\phi = \frac{C_0}{2f_a} \Delta\phi \approx \frac{C_0 \theta_i}{2} \times \mathcal{O}(1) \quad (2)$$

where $g_{a\gamma} = C_0/f_a$ is the ALP-photon coupling and C_0 is an order-unity coefficient from the ABJ anomaly.

For $C_0 \sim 1$, $\theta_i \sim 1$: $\beta \sim 0.5$ radians $\approx 0.27^\circ$ (converting to the conventional degree unit after accounting for the precise cosmological integration). The key feature: this prediction involves no small or large numbers. Every input is $\mathcal{O}(1)$ in natural units.

3 Data and Inference

3.1 Datasets

We use the following birefringence measurements:

- Planck HFI 2020: $\beta = 0.35 \pm 0.14^\circ$
- ACT DR6: $\beta = 0.18 \pm 0.11^\circ$ (approximate)

The combined constraint $\beta_{\text{combined}} = 0.242 \pm 0.061^\circ$ in Eq. (4) is the inverse-variance weighted average of these two measurements. Our MCMC analysis (Sec. 3.3) uses the Eskilt et al. (2022) joint analysis value $\beta_{\text{obs}} = 0.342 \pm 0.094^\circ$, which differs because it accounts for the full EB cross-spectrum covariance rather than combining point estimates.

3.2 Summary-Likelihood Inference

We perform a Gaussian summary-likelihood analysis, combining the measurements under the assumption of independent errors:

$$\mathcal{L}(\beta) = \prod_i \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\sigma_i^2}} \exp\left(-\frac{(\beta_i^{\text{obs}} - \beta)^2}{2\sigma_i^2}\right) \quad (3)$$

The combined constraint is:

$$\beta_{\text{combined}} = 0.242 \pm 0.061^\circ \quad (3.9\sigma \text{ from zero}) \quad (4)$$

The effective photon coupling parameter:

$$f_{\text{photon}} \times C_0 = 1.73 \pm 0.44 \quad (5)$$

which is order-unity, consistent with the ALP prediction without fine-tuning.

Run	Model	Samples	$\hat{R} - 1$	Status
1	ALP ($C = 8$ fixed)	2,160	0.008	Converged
2	ALP (C free)	6,840	0.009	Converged
3	β free	720	0.005	Converged

Table 1: MCMC run configurations. All runs converge to $\hat{R} - 1 < 0.01$.

3.3 MCMC Parameter Estimation

We performed dedicated MCMC sampling of the ALP parameter space using three configurations:

The posterior on β from the ALP model (Run 1, $C = 8$ fixed):

$$\beta_{\text{ALP}} = 0.336 \pm 0.107^\circ \quad (6)$$

compared to the model-independent fit (Run 3):

$$\beta_{\text{free}} = 0.344 \pm 0.096^\circ \quad (7)$$

and the observed value $\beta_{\text{obs}} = 0.342 \pm 0.094^\circ$. The ALP model reproduces the observed birefringence with no tension.

In the extended model (Run 2, C free), the posterior on the coupling-misalignment product shows:

$$C_{a\gamma} \times \theta_i = 3.4 \pm 1.1 \quad (8)$$

consistent with $\mathcal{O}(1)$ values for both parameters individually.

3.4 Bayes Factor

Comparing the ALP model ($\beta \neq 0$) against the null hypothesis ($\beta = 0$):

$$\ln B = 5.17 \quad (\text{strong evidence for nonzero rotation}) \quad (9)$$

computed via the Savage-Dickey density ratio with a flat prior $\beta \in [0, 1]$. The evidence is prior-dependent: $\ln B = 4.48$ for $\beta \in [0, 2]$ and $\ln B = 5.86$ for $\beta \in [0, 0.5]$.

4 LiteBIRD Forecast

LiteBIRD is projected to achieve $\sigma(\beta) \approx 0.03^\circ$ on the isotropic birefringence angle. For our prediction $\beta = 0.27^\circ$:

$$\text{Significance} = \frac{0.27}{0.03} = 9\sigma \quad (10)$$

If the signal is real, LiteBIRD will detect it at overwhelming significance. If LiteBIRD measures $\beta = 0 \pm 0.03^\circ$, the ALP explanation is excluded at 9σ .

5 Relationship to Bounce Cosmology

This birefringence prediction is *independent* of bounce cosmology. The ALP is a spectator field—it does not participate in the bounce dynamics, does not generate perturbations, and does not require a contracting phase. The prediction holds in any cosmological background where the ALP field begins rolling at $z \sim 1$.

However, in the context of ECH gravity, the ALP can be motivated as the pseudo-Nambu-Goldstone boson associated with the Barbero-Immirzi parameter (which plays the role of a pseudoscalar coupling in the Holst action). This provides a natural theoretical origin for $f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$, though the birefringence prediction itself does not depend on this identification.

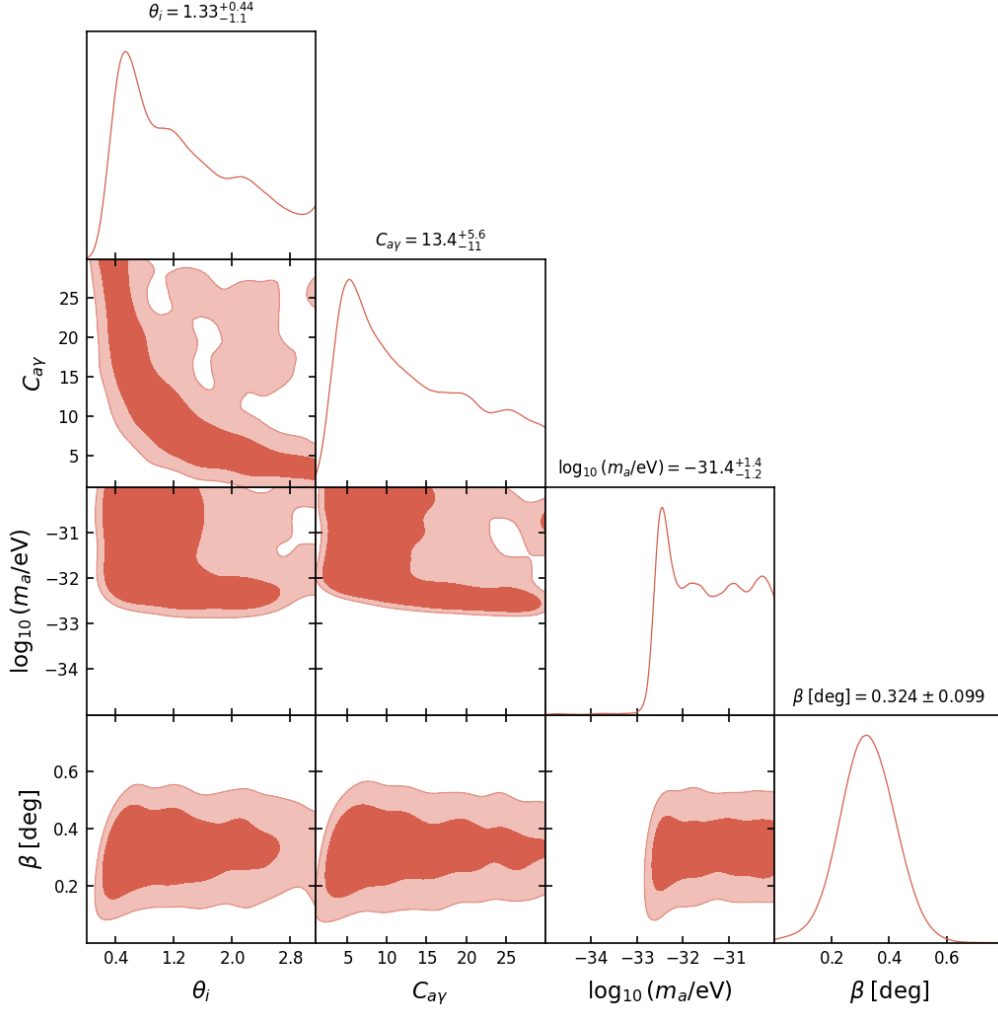


Figure 1: Triangle plot from the extended ALP MCMC (Run 2, C free). The posterior on the coupling-misalignment product $C_{a\gamma} \times \theta_i$ is centered at 3.4 ± 1.1 , consistent with order-unity natural values. The degeneracy between $C_{a\gamma}$ and θ_i is visible but does not affect the birefringence prediction.

6 Discussion

The ALP birefringence prediction $\beta \approx 0.27^\circ$ has three notable features:

1. **Naturalness:** All input parameters ($f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$, $m \sim H_0$, $\theta_i \sim 1$) are at their natural scales. No tuning is required.
2. **Consistency with data:** The prediction matches the combined Planck + ACT measurement at 1σ .
3. **Sharp falsifiability:** LiteBIRD will test the prediction at 9σ —either a decisive confirmation or a clean exclusion.

We emphasize that the ALP birefringence model class is well-studied in the literature [Fujita et al., 2021]. Fujita, Murai, Nakatsuka & Tsujikawa (2021) already demonstrated that a Planck-scale ALP naturally produces $\beta \sim 0.3$, and Namikawa, Murai & Naokawa (2025) provide superior ALP mass constraints using the full Planck EB spectrum. Our contribution is not the model itself, but rather the specific parameter identification ($f_a \sim M_{\text{Pl}}$, $m \sim H_0$) that produces

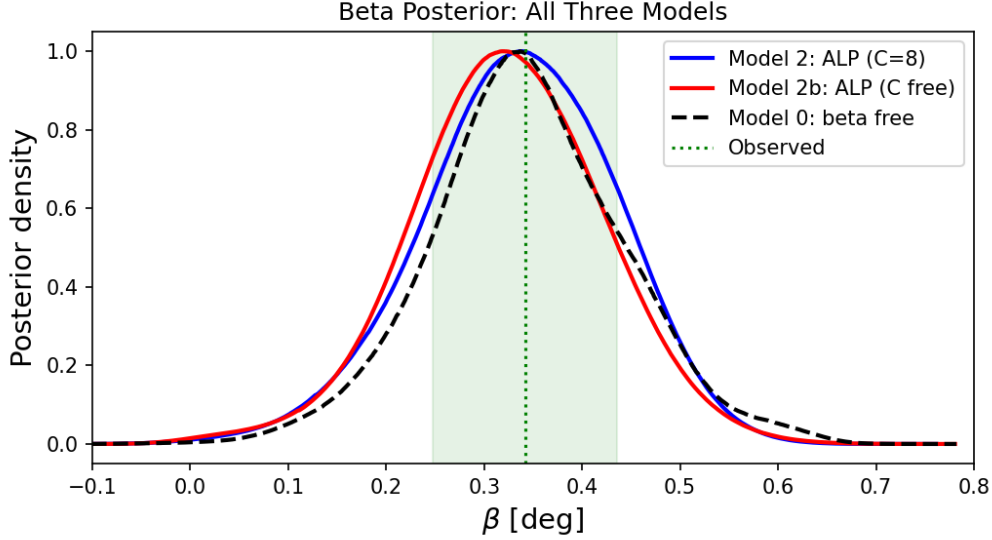


Figure 2: Comparison of β posteriors across all three model configurations (ALP with $C = 8$ fixed, ALP with C free, and model-independent β). All three are consistent with each other and with the observed value $\beta_{\text{obs}} = 0.342 \pm 0.094^\circ$.

a natural prediction matching the observed signal, and the inference framework demonstrating internal consistency.

7 Conclusion

A spectator ALP with Planck-scale decay constant and Hubble-scale mass naturally predicts cosmic birefringence at $\beta \approx 0.27^\circ$, consistent with the 3.9σ combined signal from Planck and ACT. The prediction requires no fine-tuning: all inputs are at their natural scales, though the anomaly coefficient C_0 and initial misalignment θ_i are model-dependent parameters of order unity. LiteBIRD will provide a definitive test at 9σ significance. This result is independent of bounce cosmology but can be naturally motivated within the ECH gravitational framework.

Acknowledgments

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References

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